

Mara Bell's Journal

First Night in Wilderfolk: The Tavern

I found the tavern because I followed the noise.

That is not how Tovin said I should find it. According to him, the tavern stood “just beyond the square, beside the lamp post, opposite the building with the sagging roof.” This description would have been useful if there had been a square, a lamp post, or only one building with a sagging roof.

There were three.

The sound was easier. Somebody was laughing. Somebody else was singing badly. A chair scraped across the floor, followed by a crash and a silence so complete that I stopped outside with my hand on the door.

Then a voice called, “If that was the good chair, I shall be charging you for the bad one.”

The laughter returned.

I went in.

The room smelled of smoke, wet wool, onions, and the particular sourness of people who had worked all day and were determined to prove they had not. The fire had been banked low. Lamps hung from the rafters. Their light shook whenever the door opened, which made every face appear briefly guilty.

I stood there long enough for the entire tavern to notice me.

A woman behind the counter looked me over. She had rolled-up sleeves, a flour mark on her cheek, and the steady expression of someone who had already solved six problems before breakfast.

“You’re new,” she said.

“I arrived this morning.”

“That is new.”

“I’m Mara.”

“Do you have money, Mara?”

“A little.”

“Then you’re welcome. Sit before you spend it.”

I sat at the nearest table. The chair wobbled. I decided it was the bad one.

The person beside me was a young man with black hair, a split knuckle, and the look of someone who had been told to stop doing something and had only stopped until the teller left the room.

“You helped with the house,” he said.

“I helped carry the roof beams.”

“You dropped one.”

“I did not.”

“It landed on your foot.”

“That proves I was standing in the right place.”

He considered this. “You’ll do.”

I asked his name. He said Bram, then asked whether I had brought anything interesting from the road. I told him I had brought two shirts, a spoon, a blanket, and a small knife that had belonged to my mother.

“Useful,” he said.

“Not interesting.”

“Here, useful is interesting.”

The woman behind the counter set down a bowl of stew. I looked at it. The stew looked back in the way stews do when they contain ingredients whose names are best left unknown.

“I have not paid yet,” I said.

“You have been here for twelve minutes,” she said. “That is long enough to owe the room something.”

I paid.

The first spoonful tasted of root vegetables, salt, and smoke. It was the best thing I had ever eaten. I had eaten better things before. This was different. I had been walking since dawn, and the bowl was hot, and nobody had asked me to carry it anywhere.

Across the room, Tovin was explaining the settlement to a group of people who had clearly lived here longer than he had.

“The valley is generous,” he said.

“The valley drowned your boots,” said the woman beside him.

“That was generosity in another form.”

“What form?”

“Water.”

Nobody answered. Tovin drank his drink with great dignity.

I learned several things before the bowl was empty.

The tavern was busiest after the work shift, when people came in carrying the day on their shoulders. The woman behind the counter was called Hester. She was an innkeeper, though she said the word as if it had once disappointed her. The tavern had its own hours, separate from the ordinary workday. Hester worked later than most of us, which explained why she had the expression of a person who had been awake through several versions of the same argument.

I learned that the settlement had a hotel for visitors, a school that needed a teacher, a hospital that needed a doctor, and a church that needed a priest. I learned that buildings could be complete and still useless if nobody was assigned to them. I learned that the well was already crowded and that the person who had first suggested building it was still taking credit for the idea.

I learned that the next meal would come in the morning, provided there was food.

This was said casually. Everyone in the room heard it.

The singing began again near the fire. It was the same song as before, though the singer had lost the tune and was now searching for it by force. Bram joined in. He had a stronger voice but worse judgment.

I asked Hester whether the singer was always so bad.

“Only when awake.”

The singer raised his cup. “I heard that.”

“That is because you are awake.”

The room laughed again. I laughed too, though I was not yet certain whether I was laughing at him or with everyone else. In the valley, this seemed to be a distinction people made only when they wanted to start another argument.

A child came through the door carrying a bundle of kindling almost as large as herself. She put it beside the fire, accepted a piece of bread from Hester, and left without speaking.

“Shouldn’t she be in bed?” I asked.

Bram looked at me. "Probably."

"Shouldn't someone stop her?"

"Probably."

Neither of us moved.

Outside, the light had gone blue. The first stars showed above the roofs. I could hear footsteps in the street, slow and uneven. People were going home. A few would have far to walk. Some would have no home assigned yet. Others would reach a house and discover that the roof was still more of a theory than a roof.

I thought of the beam on my foot.

Hester came around the counter and pushed the door closed against the cold. She checked the latch twice. Then she looked at me.

"Where are you sleeping?"

"In the new house."

"Which one?"

"The one with the roof beams."

"That is not a house."

“It has walls.”

“So does the well.”

I stood up.

The tavern went quiet for half a breath. Everyone watched me with the terrible interest of people who suspected I was about to make a preventable mistake.

“Where are you going?” Bram asked.

“To inspect the roof.”

“You are twenty,” he said. “You will live.”

“I intend to.”

“That is what makes it uncertain.”

Hester handed me a lamp. The flame leaned toward the door.

“Come back before the cold does,” she said.

I stepped outside. The night smelled of mud and woods-moke. Behind me, the singing resumed. Ahead of me, the unfinished house waited in the dark, looking less like shelter and more like a challenge made by someone with a sense of humor.

I had been in Wilderfolk for one day.

I had a place to sleep, a bowl in my stomach, a lamp in my hand, and a roof that might exist by morning.

It was not much.

I had arrived with less.

Author's note: Hester's tavern schedule and the separation between ordinary work hours and venue service are simulation-backed. The people, conversation, stew, bad chair, and questionable song belong to Mara's account.